A LIGHT DIVINE

When the Great Comet of 1577 shimmered in the night sky over Hindustan in November of that year, it caused much consternation. Grain would be expensive, astrologers warned, but far worse was feared, and when news arrived of the death of Shah Tahmasp of Persia, and the murder of his son and heir, Ismail, at the hands of his own sister, Pari Khanim, then the extent of the maleficent influence of the celestial visitor was well understood. There were those at court who took a more flippant view of the comet and when a courtier, the Wazir Shah Mansur, 'took to wearing a long tail to the back of his turban, they dubbed him "The Star with a Tail".'

There were a great many unusual arrivals at court in this cosmically charged year, from strange and exotic places. Badauni described the arrival of the distinguished Persian Nuqtavi thinker, the Sharif of Amul, a man he uncharitably claimed had 'betrayed the filthiness of his disposition' and had therefore been dispatched from the Deccan, where he had been 'set on a donkey and shown about the city in disgrace'. The Nuqtavis were a millennial creed who based their knowledge on astrological theories and the science of alphabetical letters. Blaming the distressingly tolerant nature of Akbar's court, which welcomed such heretical thinkers, Badauni noted bitterly that 'since Hindustan is a wide place, where there is an open field for all licentiousness, and no one interferes with another's business, so that every one can do just as he please', the sharif had been able to make his way to the Mughal court. The sharif was 'ridiculous in his exterior, ugly in shape, with his neck stooping forward', and his deceitful blue eyes betrayed the falsehood and hypocrisy of his nature, according to Badauni. Jahangir, too, who wrote about him in his memoir was circumspect about the scholar. 'During my exalted father's time,' wrote Jahangir musingly, 'he left his dervish garb of poverty and attained the rank of Amir and commander.'

Akbar, however, enjoyed many animated personal interviews with the visitor, who explained to the Mughal Padshah the tenets of the Nuqtavis, even as Akbar continued to offer namaaz five times a day. Hakim Ain ul-Mulk Shirazi, who had led the delegation to the Deccan, returned with elephants, other presents, and perhaps some startling news about the Shah